soon stopped by a traffic constable. Mr Bansal, dreading the consequences the driver would be subjected to, stepped out of the car to ask the constable to forgive the poor fellow. The constable, who turned out to be an ardent cricket fan, recognized Mr Bansal and promptly decided to let the driver off.

Third Test, Chennai, 18–22 March 2001

The Australians started well, with Matthew Hayden once again leading the way. He had batted wonderfully throughout the series and was the only Australian batsman who looked comfortable against Harbhajan. He scored an impressive double hundred and the Australians notched up a first-innings score of 391. I bowled a good spell on the first day, carrying on from Kolkata, and got the ball to turn sharply but did not take any wickets, but by the end of the spell, the skin of my fingers had started to peel off and I was finding it hard to grip the ball.

Australia, who were at 326–3 at the end of day one, suffered a collapse on day two, ending up with just 391. It all started with an unusual dismissal. Against skipper Steve Waugh we were trying to keep things tight and when he tried taking a single to short cover I prevented the run and said a few things to him on the lines that he was trying to get away from the strike. Rahul, fielding at leg slip, offered a few words and before long we were able to get under Waugh's skin. Finally, when Harbhajan beat him with a good off-spinner and appealed for lbw, Waugh, in a momentary lapse of concentration, moved the ball away with his hand. We appealed for handling the ball, and the Australian captain was on his way back to the dressing room. Mission accomplished, we didn't say another word to him.

I was determined to make amends for my batting failures in Kolkata and had practised hard against reverse swing in the gap between the two Test matches. I decided to follow the ball throughout my innings and not to lose sight of it at any time. To play well against reverse swing you have to keep your eye on the ball for as long as possible and that was what I did all day, as it was passed from the wicketkeeper to the slips and through the hands of various fielders back to the bowler. I focused on the ball and nothing else. The only time I was not following the ball was when I was talking to the non-striker about something. As the bowler came in to bowl I concentrated on the ball and monitored the release as